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According to Edward Fry, there are three reading speeds: Study reading speed, Average reading speed and Skimming speed. Study reading speed is generally used to read material which demands total comprehension and retention of its meaning, for example, while preparing for an examination. Average reading speed is used for everyday reading of newspapers, magazines and novels etc. Skimming is the fastest reading speed and is generally used for getting an overall idea of the material read. Scanning is another useful tool for speeding up reading. While scanning, you look for specific information without reading everything.

A few practical hints to help you do activities under reading comprehension passages:

1. Read the passage carefully and try to grasp its main theme.

2. Pay attention to the meanings of words (connotation), phrases and sentences.

3. Grasp the manner in which the writer has developed his ideas and thoughts.

4. Read all the questions in the sequence and conceptualize the answers.

5. Read the passage again focussing on the content and answer the questions appropriately. Find accurate solutions for vocabulary exercises too.

6. Go through your answers to check spelling, punctuation and grammar.

I. Now, read the following passage on "Laughter Therapy" and answer the questions that follow.

1. Laughing is an excellent way to reduce stress in our lives; it can help you to cope with and survive a stressful life. Laughter provides full-scale support for your muscles and unleashes a rush of stress busting endorphins. Since our body cannot distinguish between real and fake laughter, anything that makes you giggle will have a positive impact.

2. Laughter Therapy aims to get people laughing, in groups and individual sessions and can help reduce stress, make people and employees happier and more committed, as well as improve their interpersonal skills. This laughter comes from the body and not the mind.

3. Laughter Yoga (Hasya yoga) is a practice involving prolonged voluntary laughter. It aims to get people laughing in groups. It is practised in the early mornings in open-parks. It has been made popular as an exercise routine developed by Indian physician Madan Kataria, who writes about the practice in his 2002 book 'Laugh for no reason'. Laughter Yoga is based on the belief that voluntary laughter provides the same physiological as well as psychological benefits as spontaneous laughter.